Photographs by **CHANDRADEEP KUMAR**





jewel in our crown". "It will make India a great power in the field of hockey and dominate the game for decades to come. This stadium will be a nerve centre of global hockey.... This initiative of ours will inspire our young players and will create many champions in coming days," he added.

The emergence of a state-of-the-art facility co-hosting an international sporting event necessitated the need for an airport. The airstrip at Rourkela aerodome was expanded and a terminal building set up to launch the Rourkela Airport. Those flying in are certain to notice a giant sculpture of a hockey player—put together with scrapped steel parts of vehicles—that dominates the approach to the airport.

21,000
No. of seats at the Birsa Munda Hockey Stadium, making it the world's largest by chair capacity

₹261 crore
Amount the Odisha government has spent to build the stadium in the state's tribal belt

15 months
Time taken to build the stadium after foundation laid in Feb. 2021

₹75 crore
Odisha's budget for the 2023 Hockey World Cup. In 2018, it was Rs 67 crore

₹911 crore
Odisha's annual sports budget. Upcoming projects include an indoor athletics stadium

₹1 crore
Amount CM Naveen Patnaik has pledged to each player of Team India if it wins the World Cup

₹100 crore
Value of Odisha's sponsorship deal with Hockey India to support the men's and women's teams till 2023

SUNDARGARH, THE CRADLE OF HOCKEY

One of the lines of India's hockey anthem goes: "*Kehta hai Odisha, hockey hai dil mera.*" Nowhere is that spirit more alive than in Sundargarh district. Such is the craze that World Cup tickets to matches in Rourkela were sold out in a few days. Home to big hockey academies like Panposh Hockey Academy, SAIL Academy and SAI Sports Hostel, the game is a way of life here. It is said that hockey first came to the region in the 19th century with European Christian missionaries, who introduced the sport in the schools they set up. Initially, it was predominantly the tribals who took it up, using bamboo sticks to play on muddy grounds. By the 1980s, villages across Odisha's second biggest district began to hold Khasi Cup, a tournament where teams would vie for the winning prize—a khasi, or a goat. The tradition still continues, with the competition being both a motivation and a financial incentive for the economically challenged participants.

"Odisha hockey is purely Sundargarh hockey," says Satish Sharma, a journalist with the local newspaper *Sambad*, who has been covering the sport for nearly four decades. "Nearly 90 per cent of hockey players from Sundargarh who made it to national team are Christians." Rourkela's Hockey Chowk bears witness to some of the heroes and heroines of Odisha hockey. Peter Tirkey was the first to make it to the junior national team in 1982; 14 years later, Dilip Tirkey would be its first Olympian. Later, brothers Ignace and Prabodh Tirkey would both captain the Indian men's hockey team. In the current national team, Sundargarh has two representatives in defenders Neelam Sanjeeb Xess and Amit Rohidas, who is